THE LEADING CAST

TRIPURA

MANIK SAHA, 70
Chief Minister



The former Congressman joined the BJP in 2016 and was made chief minister in May 2022 to fight anti-incumbency and growing organisational dissent. He now has his task cut out to lead the BJP back to power amid challenges from a CPI (M) alliance and new tribal party, Tipra Motha

MANIK SARKAR, 74
Former chief minister



The CPI(M) leader leads the party's fightback. Has joined hands with old rival Congress

PRADYOT MANIKYA DEBBARMA, 44
Chairman, Tipra Motha



The former Congressman has launched his own outfit, Tipra Motha, to fight for tribal rights. The party swept the tribal autonomous council polls in 2021. Most likely to play decisive role in 20 ST seats

MEGHALAYA

CONRAD SANGMA, 45
Chief Minister



The NPP chief faces challenges from an emerging TMC led by former CM and Congressman Mukul Sangma and former ally BJP

MUKUL SANGMA, 57
Former Chief Minister



The former Congressman joined the TMC last year with several other MLAs. Prashant Kishor's I-PAC is helping him. Can be the gamechanger

NAGALAND

NEIPHU RIO, 72
Chief Minister



The strongman of Nagaland politics faces little challenge. The only concern has been the seat-sharing agreement with ally BJP

where Conrad and his family members—inheritors of the legacy of former Lok Sabha speaker P.A. Sangma—are strong players. In the 2019 Lok Sabha polls, Conrad's sister Agatha defeated Mukul in Tura.

The Garo Hills have 24 assembly seats, while the Khasi Hills, dominated by the Khasi tribe, and Jaintia Hills, mostly inhabited by Jaintia tribe, together have the rest of the seats. For both Conrad and Mukul, the battle is not just to retain their stranglehold over the Garos, who account for 20 per cent of Meghalaya's population, but to win maximum seats in areas dominated by the Khasis, who constitute 70 per cent of the population.

NAGALAND

The incumbent government in Nagaland faces the least challenge. In fact, there is hardly any opposition. In September 2021, the Naga People's Front (NPF), the principal opposition in the Nagaland assembly, joined the Nationalist Democratic Progressive Party (NDPP)-led government, leaving the state opposition-less. In 2018, the NPF had emerged as the single largest party, winning 26 seats in the 60-member house. The government was, however, formed by the NDPP, which won 18 seats in alliance with the BJP, which had won 12 seats. For the uninitiated, the NDPP came into being in 2018 after Chief Minister Neiphu Rio split from the NPF, the oldest ally of the BJP in the Northeast.

The NPF joined the Rio government to "work collectively towards achieving a peaceful and amicable solution" to the protracted Naga political issue. Though that solution is still not in sight, in 2022, 21 NPF MLAs defected to the NDPP. And in the run-up to the 2023 polls, the party is fighting an existential battle despite being part of the government. The NDPP-BJP alliance has announced its seat-sharing formula—40 for NDPP and 20 for BJP—leaving no space for the NPF. Similar is the fate of the Congress, which doesn't have a single MLA. The grand old party will be jostling for space with other players, such as the Janata Dal (United), Rashtriya Janata Dal, the Aam Aadmi Party and the NPP.

Despite the assurance of a smooth run ahead, the NDPP-BJP alliance faces internal challenges. The former has 48 legislators in the outgoing assembly. But as per the seat-sharing agreement, it can field only 40, making the rest vulnerable to poaching. On January 24, a four-time MLA and former minister, Imkong L. Imchen, defected to the BJP. The 40:20 arrangement has also caused dissent—some state BJP leaders feel the hard work put in to build organisations in certain constituencies will go waste if those seats are "given away" to the NDPP. Besides, several politicians who had joined the BJP with a "ticket assurance" are now rebelling, accusing it of going back on its promise.

The BJP brass is not too worried—a problem of plenty indicates the party's acceptability in a state with nearly 90 per cent Christian population. With India hosting the G20 Leaders' Summit this year, it will be a great display of the BJP's inclusivity at a global stage. ■